

Padma Priya, *52*
Director, National Institute for Research in Tuberculosis

THE TB WARRIOR

INDIA, WHICH HAS LONG HAD the reputation of being the world's tuberculosis (TB) capital, had in 2017 set the target of eliminating the disease from the country by 2025. The 67-year-old National Institute for Research in Tuberculosis (NIRT) in Chennai, led by Dr Padma Priya, plays a vital role in striving to meet that goal. The institute, renowned for its clinical trials expertise, has not only been studying possibilities for a TB vaccine but also a stool-based diagnostics method for one of the biggest killer infections in India. In the last year, the institute put out around 35 research publications.

But TB is not the only fight NIRT is fighting. "Our work was astounding during the lockdown too. We were working in rotation and also played a key role in vaccine trials for the virus," says Padma Priya. In 2021, she was leading the phase 2/3 human studies for the Covishield vaccine, and the work became the basis for the Drug Controller General of India's (DCGI) emergency use authorisation to Covishield. Later, the ICMR selected NIRT among other centres to track Covaxin's rollout.

Born in Tamil Nadu, Padma's father was in the army and mother was a history teacher. It was Padma Priya's grandmother who wanted her to be a doctor. Talking about deep-rooted gender bias in the infectious diseases research space, Padma Priya recalls how there have been many a time when she is the only woman in a room at NIRT, where she's been working for 23 years now. "Research is hard work. You will face difficulties, more so as a woman. But you have to continue," she says.

Researchers, says Padma Priya, must have patience; most good research takes at least three years to get published. As director, she hopes her work will encourage more people to take up research. "It is something we are working towards," she says. ■

–Sonali Acharjee

ACCOMPLISHMENT

As the director of the National Institute for Research in Tuberculosis, Padma Priya has not only been at the forefront of India's fight against the disease but has also expanded the boundaries of clinical research and trials

HOLDING FAST

"A senior gave me this advice once—in Tamil, there is a saying, that only a tree that has a lot of mangoes has stones hurled at it"

↘ US DAYS
Her time in the US during her master's gave Padma Priya confidence as an individual. "I learned swimming and driving at the age of 33. Everyone must try to have this kind of exposure. Age doesn't matter," she says

↘ GRANDMA'S DREAM
Her grandmother was interested in community work and wanted to be a doctor, but couldn't. Padma Priya herself grew up in an orthodox joint family where being a doctor was her only option. She only ever wrote two entrance exams—medicine and engineering